

Networking Tips

COURSE 5 | PROCERT SKILLS

Networking is one of the most important things that you can do in the business world. It's rare that a business opportunity, new project, or job will appear in front of you without some networking on your part. The connections that you make today can help you set up beneficial relationships that can pay dividends in the future. You can build a strong business network by using the following tips.

Consider creating and developing a LinkedIn profile

LinkedIn is a commonly used tool for professional networking. Consider creating a LinkedIn profile and developing it so you can connect with other professionals. If you create a profile on LinkedIn, be careful about what you post. Though you can use LinkedIn to make connections, it can also be used in ways that might prevent potential connections. If you decide to create a LinkedIn profile, the following list includes some general tips for setting up and using LinkedIn:

Keep it professional: LinkedIn is a business tool. It's best to keep personal posts and life events for social media networks that focus on those areas. An example of an appropriate post to LinkedIn could include getting a new job, completing a large project, or asking for opinions on a business-focused problem that you're working on.

Headshot: Make sure that your profile picture is professional. You don't need to hire a photographer, but the picture you use should be appropriate to share in a business meeting.

Messages: When you send messages to other LinkedIn users, make sure that they're relevant to the person that you're sending them to. Unsolicited requests for jobs, internships, or mentorships might result in your account being blocked.

Profile: List relevant skills, certifications, and work experience on your profile. It's important to edit your profile—you don't need to include every job you've worked throughout your life—but the information that you post should be relevant to your career goals.

Keep it personal: Focus on adding people to your LinkedIn network that you already have a virtual or in-person connection with. Resist the urge to add people that you don't already know in some way.

Attending events

Attending local meetups and other business-focused events can help build your network. These events could be free events hosted by local companies, or paid conferences that you attend. While you're at the event, focus on being social with the other attendees. Even if being social isn't comfortable for you, remember that these events exist for making professional connections. Try to strike up conversations based on a mutual interest or a work project that that you're currently assigned to.

For locating these sorts of events, your search engine of choice is the best tool. For example, if you're interested in attending a DevOps meetup in Pittsburgh, you could search for "DevOps meetup Pittsburgh". You might be surprised with the amount of results that you get.

Maintaining relationships

Relationships need maintenance. You don't need to constantly message your contacts, but you do need to occasionally check in with the people in your network. Did they get a new job? You could congratulate them. Did they post something interesting to an online platform? Leave a comment. Maintaining lines of communication are important for building and keeping relationships.

Help goes both ways

Just like people in your network are willing to help you, it's important for you to also help others. After all, a business network isn't something that only benefits one person. In order to maintain a powerful business network, it's vital that you ask others how you can help them. Is there a job you could refer them to? How about a project that they need help with? By showing that you're there to support others in your network, you'll foster deeper and longer lasting bonds with your connections.

